

Aleutian Trench
This deep trench is formed by the Pacific Plate being pushed under the North American Plate. Volcanoes have formed the Aleutian chain of islands.

North American Plate

Earth's crust

San Andreas Fault
A transform boundary, where the Pacific and North American plates grind against each other.

Philippine Plate

The outermost shell of the Earth is the crust. It is not an unbroken covering, but huge plates of rock that drift over a deep layer of semisolid rocks, called the mantle.

Caribbean Plate

Cocos Plate

Peru–Chile Trench
As oceanic crust pushes under continental crust, deep trenches like this form under the ocean.

Pacific Plate

Australian-Indian Plate

**THE OLDEST PARTS
OF EARTH'S CRUST
ARE ABOUT 4 BILLION
YEARS OLD.**

Nazca Plate

East Pacific Rise
This boundary is spreading about 5.9 in (15 cm) per year—about four times faster than your fingernails grow!

Oceanic crust
The Pacific Plate is the largest plate that is made entirely of oceanic crust. Oceanic crust is thinner, but denser (heavier), than continental crust.

Antarctic Plate

Continental crust
The Antarctic Plate, like most plates, contains an older and thicker type of crust called continental crust. It is made of lighter rock than oceanic crust and sits higher, forming all the world's land, including Antarctica.